Batswana Student Association(BSA) Dance

Types:

Setapa

One of the most celebrated dances around the BaTswana nation. It originates from Botswana, it was formed by the Bakgatla tribe around 1400s. It is characterised by strong foot stamping and rhythmic movement. Traditionally performed by men, often during celebrations and competitions.

Borankana

Originates from Botswana, is a modern traditional dance that mixes older Tswana rhythms with newer styles. It became popular in cultural festivals and competitions.

Cultural importance

Tswana dances preserve history and identity, teach discipline and cooperation, and they strengthen community bonds.

Mohobelo – Full Research Overview

1. Origin & Historical Background

Mohobelo dates back to the **late 1800s**, during and after major regional conflicts like the **Lifaqane wars** and the **Great Trek**.

- Basotho men guarding villages in the **Maluti Mountains** would:
  - Sing together
  - Add rhythmic movements
  - Practice unity and readiness for conflict
- Over time, these movements evolved into a **structured dance form**.

It was originally:

- A **warrior dance**
- A way to build **strength, morale, and unity**

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2. Who Performs Mohobelo?

- Traditionally performed **only by Basotho men**
- Often done in **groups or troupes**
- Led by a **praise singer (poet)** who controls rhythm and energy

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3. Dance Style & Movements

Mohobelo is known for its **intense, energetic movement style**:

- High kicks
- Heavy stomping

- Sliding and leaping motions
- Swinging sticks or clubs

These movements symbolize:

- **Masculinity**
- **Strength**
- **War readiness**

Dancers often break formation briefly to perform **solo expressive moves**, showing skill and personality.

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4. Music & Performance Structure

Mohobelo is not just a dance — it's a **full performance system**:

- Uses **call-and-response singing**
- Includes:
  - Deep male vocals
  - Praise poetry
  - Whistling and humming sounds

The leader improvises lyrics, often:

- Political
- Social
- Humorous
- Competitive

This creates a **live interaction** between dancers and singers.

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5. Clothing & Props

Traditional attire originally included:

- Basotho blanket
- Shield and spear
- Knobkerrie (club)

Modern performances often use:

- Black trousers and shoes
- Shirts and vests
- Sticks decorated with cloth or bandanas

These outfits represent both:

- **Cultural identity**
- **Evolution of the dance over time**

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6. Cultural Significance

Mohobelo plays a **major role in Basotho culture**:

- **Symbolism**
  - Represents **manhood and discipline**
  - Encourages **teamwork and unity**
  - Shows **cultural pride**
- **Social Functions**

It is performed at:

- Festivals
- Community gatherings
- Weddings
- Heritage celebrations

It also historically helped:

- Motivate workers during farming (letsema)
- Strengthen community bonds

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7. Spiritual & Ancestral Meaning

Mohobelo is deeply tied to **ancestral beliefs**:

- Performances can honor **ancestors**
- Seen as a connection between:
  - The living
  - The spiritual world

It reinforces identity and heritage within the Basotho community.

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8. Influence of Migration (South Africa)

When Basotho men worked in **South African mines**:

- Mohobelo became a way to:
  - Stay connected to home
  - Build brotherhood
- Groups began competing and performing publicly
- This led to:
  - New styles
  - Modern costumes
  - Wider popularity

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9. Modern-Day Mohobelo

Today, Mohobelo is:

- A **cultural performance art**
- A symbol of **Basotho heritage**
- Performed in:
    - Lesotho
    - South Africa

It's commonly seen during:

- Cultural festivals
- Heritage Day celebrations
- Tourism events

It continues to represent **unity, pride, and identity**.

Famo Group Dance & Music – Full Research

1. What is Famo?

Famo is a traditional Basotho **music and dance culture** from Lesotho that combines:

- Accordion-based music
- Strong rhythmic drumming
- Energetic dancing
- Storytelling through singing

It is one of the **most important cultural music styles in Lesotho today**.

Unlike Mohobelo (war dance), Famo is:

- More **social and expressive**
- Strongly linked to **daily life and urban experiences**

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2. Origin & Historical Background

Famo began in the **1920s** among Basotho migrant workers in **South African mines**.

Why it started:

- Men worked far from home
- Needed entertainment and connection
- Gathered in **shebeens (informal bars)**

👉 They:

- Sang traditional songs
- Added instruments like the **accordion**
- Developed dance styles to match the rhythm

Over time, this became a **distinct cultural genre**.

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3. Music & Dance Style

Famo is **both music AND dance**, not just one.

Music features:

- Accordion (main instrument)
- Drum (often homemade)
- Deep, powerful vocals
- Call-and-response singing

Dance style:

- Fast, rhythmic footwork
- Hip and body movements
- Expressive, sometimes provocative gestures
- Often performed in pairs or groups

The dance is designed to **match the beat and storytelling**.

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4. Lyrics & Meaning

Famo songs are known for **powerful storytelling**.

They often include:

- Social commentary
- Migration struggles
- Love and relationships
- Humor and insults (competitive style)

It's similar to:

- Praise poetry (lithoko)
- Verbal battles or lyrical competition

Famo is not just entertainment — it's a **voice of the people**.

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5. Who Performs Famo?

Originally:

- Mostly **Basotho men**

Later:

- Women became major performers too
- Famous female artists like **Puseletso Seema** helped shape the culture

Performers usually form:

- **Bands or groups**
- With a lead singer + instrumentalists

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6. Dance Culture & Performance Environment

Famo dance developed in **informal, social environments**:

- Shebeens (bars)
- Mining camps
- Community gatherings

Dance characteristics:

- Highly interactive
- Audience participation
- Improvised movements

Early performances were sometimes:

- **Provocative or rebellious**
- Seen as controversial by society

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7. Cultural Significance

Famo is deeply important to Basotho identity.

◇ **Social Role**

- Builds **unity among migrant workers**
- Expresses **real-life struggles**
- Creates **community bonding**

◇ **Cultural Identity**

- Represents **Basotho resilience**
- Connects:
  - Rural traditions
  - Urban life

◇ **National Importance**

- Now performed at:
  - Festivals
  - National celebrations
  - Cultural events

⚠ **8. Controversy & Gang Associations**

Famo has a **complex modern history**.

- Rival groups formed around musicians
- Some became linked to:
  - Gangs
  - Illegal mining networks

This led to:

- Violence between rival factions
- Political and social tensions

Important:

This is **not the culture itself**, but how it evolved in certain environments.

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9. Famous Famo Artists & Groups

Some key figures include:

- Apollo Ntabanyane ("King of Famo")
- Puseletso Seema ("Queen of Famo")
- Chakela (modern influential artist)

Groups often form **factions or styles**, like:

- Terene
- Seakhi

🔄 10. Evolution Over Time

1920s–1950s

- Origin in mines
- Basic instruments

1960s–1980s

- Recording and radio exposure
- Growth in Lesotho

1990s–2000s

- Cassette era → widespread popularity

2010s–Present

- Fusion with:
    - Hip-hop
    - Modern African music

Still evolving but remains culturally rooted.